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Latah County Library's Food for Fines 2015



George Williams



George Williams Associated Press

Springtime at all of the branches of the Latah County Library District means one thing to a lot of library users: Food for Fines.

During the two weeks from April 12-25, if you have late fees on any library materials owned by the Latah County Library District, you can pay those fees by bringing non-perishable food items to any of the seven Latah County library branches. Fees will be forgiven at the rate of \$2 in fees for every non-perishable food item and all of the food collected will go to local food banks. Food will only be accepted for the payment of late fees on items owned by the Latah County Library - if you have any fees for lost or damaged items, or if you have fees on items owned by other VALNet libraries, you can't pay them with food.

We run the Food for Fines campaign every year for a couple of reasons. For one thing, we like to give our patrons an alternative way of taking care of their late fees other than having to bring in money. Patrons with late fees on their library accounts are blocked from using some of the online services offered through the catalog, such as downloadable e-books and e-audiobooks. They can't use their account to renew their checkouts or to place holds. Accounts just work better when late fees are paid off and sometimes food donations are more manageable than cash.

More importantly, though, we run our Food for Fines campaign because it helps our communities. The Latah County Library District operates libraries in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Moscow, Potlatch and Troy. In the past five years our Food for Fines campaigns have collected more than 3,500 pounds of food for food banks in these communities. Just like last year, our local food banks need help because of economic conditions.

So please come in to your local library during our Food for Fines campaign and help your community by bringing in food for your local food bank. If you have late fees, we'll be happy to forgive them and if you don't have any late fees, we'll still accept any food you'd like to contribute.

George Williams is the access services manager for the Latah County Library District.

